

shock of Lincoln's death, there was further consternation at the thought of Johnson as the new president.

His position was politically awkward. A lifetime Democrat, he found himself at the head of a Republican administration, and it soon became apparent that his political agenda was very different from that of much of the party.

Controversy brews

The falling out began barely six weeks into Johnson's presidency, when he issued two key proclamations. One granted amnesty and restored property to almost all Southerners prepared to swear allegiance to the Union. The other set in motion a process by which former Confederate states could be readmitted to the Union.

Although intended specifically for North Carolina, it came to be seen as a model for other states as well. The process provided for the election of a representative body to frame a new state constitution. Crucially, the electorate involved would be exclusively white.

Johnson's proposals brought into focus the clash between two very different views of the future of the nation. On one side, the radical wing of the Republican Party imagined a transformed South in which emancipated Black people would have the same citizenship rights as their white neighbors, including the right to vote. On the other, Democrats and moderate Republicans, as well as the vast body of white opinion in the South itself, visualized a situation in which little would have changed in the postwar states except for the abolition of slavery as an institution.

Johnson was the only former U.S. president to serve in the Senate after leaving the White House. He was re-elected as a senator for Tennessee, a post he had previously held from 1857 to 1862.